

سُورَةُ الْعَادِيَّاتِ



Sūrat al-‘Ādiyāt

The Chargers — an āyah-by-āyah tafsīr

Drawing on Ibn Kathīr · as-Sa‘dī · al-Jalālayn · aṭ-Ṭabarī · al-Qurṭubī · al-Baghawī

The Sūrah at a glance

11

āyāt

100

in muṣḥaf order

30

juz' ('Ammā)

Makkī

per the majority; some say Madanī

Names of the sūrah

- Al-‘Ādiyāt — “the Chargers”, from āyah 1
- Wal-‘Ādiyāt — its opening words

Central theme

Allah swears by the war-horses that charge in His path — then exposes man: ungrateful to his Lord, witness to his own ingratitude, and fierce in his love of wealth. The graves will be emptied and the hearts laid bare.

Context: the oath by the horses

Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī & Ṣaḥīḥ Muslim

The Prophet ﷺ said:

“Goodness is tied to the forelocks of horses until the Day of Resurrection.”

And when he ﷺ marched on a people, he would wait until dawn: if he heard the adhān he held back, and if not, he raided at daybreak.

— the very scene of āyah 3: *fal-mughhīrāti ṣubḥā*.

Why swear by horses?

as-Sa’dī: Allah’s signs and blessings in them are evident — no other animal serves so loyally, even into danger.

A note on virtues

No authentic report singles out a special reward for reciting this sūrah; its value lies in its message.

The tafsīr sources in this deck



Ibn Kathīr

d. 774 AH

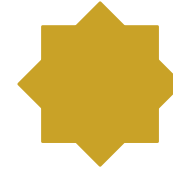
Tafsīr al-Qur'ān al-'Aẓīm — explains Qur'ān by Qur'ān, then Sunnah, then the Companions and Tābi'ūn.



as-Sa'dī

d. 1376 AH

Taysīr al-Karīm ar-Raḥmān — concise, focused on meanings, guidance and practical lessons.



al-Jalālayn

al-Maḥallī & as-Suyūṭī

Tafsīr al-Jalālayn — a word-by-word gloss; brief and precise in its definitions.



Others

aṭ-Ṭabarī • al-Qurṭubī • al-Baghawī

Used for the range of early opinions, language and further points.

Note: tafsīr points are summarised and paraphrased in English — check against the Arabic originals before teaching.

Three movements in eleven āyāt

1-5

The oath

Horses charging, panting, striking sparks, raiding at dawn, stirring dust, piercing the enemy's ranks.

6-8

The verdict on man

Ungrateful to his Lord, a witness to it himself, and intense in his love of wealth.

9-11

The reminder

Graves emptied, hearts exposed — and his Lord fully aware of them that Day.

Āyah 1-2 · Panting, striking sparks



وَالْعَادِيَّاتِ ضَبْحًا ﴿١﴾ فَالْمُورِيَّاتِ قَدْحًا

By the racers, panting, and the producers of sparks [when] striking,

Ibn Kathīr

Allah swears by horses charging in His path, panting — ḍabḥ is the sound of a horse's breath as it runs. Their hooves strike rocks and throw sparks. 'Alī held these were camels running from 'Arafah to Muzdalifah; Ibn 'Abbās said horses — and Ibn Kathīr and Ibn Jarīr prefer horses.

as-Sa'dī

He swears by horses because of His clear signs and blessings in them. They run so hard their breath is heard, and their hooves strike fire from the stones.

al-Jalālayn

Al-ādiyāt: horses running in battle. Ḍabḥ: the sound of their breathing. Al-mūriyāt qadḥā: striking fire from the rocks with their hooves, at night.

Āyah 3–5 · The dawn raid

3–5

فَالْمُغِيرَاتِ صُبْحًا ﴿٣﴾ فَأَثَرْنَ بِهِ نَقْعًا ﴿٤﴾ فَوَسَطْنَ بِهِ جَمْعًا

And the chargers at dawn, stirring up thereby [clouds of] dust, arriving thereby in the centre collectively,

Ibn Kathīr

They raid at daybreak, as the Prophet ﷺ would wait for dawn and listen for the adhān. They raise dust where they charge, and plunge together into the midst of the enemy.

as-Sa‘dī

Morning is the usual time of a raid. In their charge they stir up dust, then burst together into the middle of the enemy’s gathering.

al-Jalālayn

Al-mughīrāt ṣubḥā: raiding the enemy at dawn through their riders. Naq‘: dust. Wasaṭna bihi jam‘ā: entering into the midst of the enemy’s gathering.

Āyah 6 • Man is ungrateful



إِنَّ الْإِنْسَانَ لِرَبِّهِ لَكَنُودٌ

Indeed mankind, to his Lord, is ungrateful.

Ibn Kathīr

This is what is sworn upon. Kanūd means ungrateful, denying his Lord's favours (Ibn 'Abbās, Mujāhid and others). Al-Ḥasan al-Baṣrī: he counts the calamities and forgets the blessings.

as-Sa'dī

By nature man withholds what he owes his Lord: he is lax in duties and holds back the good — except those whom Allah guides.

al-Jalālayn

Kanūd: ungrateful (kafūr), denying His blessings.

Āyah 7 • His own witness



وَإِنَّهُ عَلَىٰ ذَٰلِكَ لَشَهِيدٌ

And indeed, he is to that a witness.

Ibn Kathīr

Two views: Allah is witness to it (Qatādah, Sufyān), or man himself testifies to his ingratitude — it shows in his words and deeds (Muḥammad ibn Kaʿb al-Quraḏī). The flow of the passage favours the second.

as-Saʿdī

Man testifies against himself about what he knows of his own ingratitude; he cannot deny it, for it is plain.

al-Jalālayn

He bears witness against himself through his own deeds.

Āyah 8 • Fierce in love of wealth



وَإِنَّهُ لَحَبِّ الْخَيْرِ لَشَدِيدٌ

And indeed he is, in love of wealth, intense.

Ibn Kathīr

Al-khayr here is wealth. Two meanings, both true: he loves wealth intensely, and he is miserly because of that love.

as-Sa‘dī

His love of wealth drives him to abandon what is obligatory — he puts his own desire before the pleasure of his Lord.

al-Jalālayn

Al-khayr: wealth. Shadīd: intense in his love of it, and so stingy with it.

Āyah 9–10 · Graves emptied, hearts exposed

9–10

أَفَلَا يَعْلَمُ إِذَا بُعْثِرَ مَا فِي الْقُبُورِ ﴿٩﴾ وَحُصِّلَ مَا فِي الصُّدُورِ

But does he not know that when the contents of the graves are scattered and that within the breasts is obtained,

Ibn Kathīr

When the dead are brought out of their graves, and the secrets people hid in their hearts are brought into the open.

as-Sa‘dī

Allah brings the dead out for resurrection, and what is in the hearts — good and evil — becomes manifest. Secrets become public.

al-Jalālayn

Bu‘thira: brought out and raised. Huṣṣila: made clear and set forth — the disbelief and faith within.

Āyah 11 • Their Lord is fully aware



إِنَّ رَبَّهُمْ بِهِمْ يَوْمَئِذٍ خَبِيرٌ

Indeed, their Lord with them, that Day, is [fully] Aware.

Ibn Kathīr

He knows everything they did and will repay them in full; He does not wrong anyone even an atom's weight.

as-Sa'dī

He knows their outward and inward, the hidden and the open, and will recompense them for it.

al-Jalālayn

He knows — so He will repay them. “That Day” is specified though He always knows, because it is the Day of recompense.

Key words of the sūrah

ḍabḥan

panting breath of a running horse

ضَبْحًا

qadḥan

striking sparks

قَدْحًا

al-mughīrāt

those raiding, charging

الْمُغِيرَاتِ

naq'an

dust

نَقْعًا

la-kanūd

ungrateful, denying favours

لَكَنُودٌ

al-khayr

here: wealth

الْخَيْرِ

bu'thira

overturned, brought out

بُعْثِرَ

ḥuṣṣila

extracted, laid bare

حُصِّلَ

From the wider tafsīr tradition

aṭ-Ṭabarī

Records the difference between ‘Alī (camels of Ḥajj) and Ibn ‘Abbās (horses of jihād), and inclines to horses, since ḍabḥ — panting — is properly a horse’s sound.

al-Qurṭubī

Explains kanūd from Arabic usage: land that grows nothing is called kanūd — so the kanūd man gives nothing back of the good he receives.

al-Baghawī

On āyah 10: what was concealed in hearts will be gathered and displayed, like grain separated from chaff — nothing hidden remains hidden.

The loyal horse, the ungrateful man

وَالْعَادِيَاتِ

The horse

- Fed by its master — and runs for him
- Charges into danger at his command
- Breathless, bruised, yet does not hold back

→ Gives everything for one who feeds it

لَكَنُودٌ

Ungrateful man

- Fed, clothed and guided by his Lord
- Holds back what he owes Him
- Counts calamities, forgets blessings

→ Withholds from the One who gives all

Lessons to carry



Read the oath

What Allah swears by is honoured; striving in His path is noble (āyāt 1–5).



Know your nature

Ingratitude is the default — guidance is the cure (āyah 6).



Be honest with yourself

Your own life testifies to your gratitude or lack of it (āyah 7).



Guard against greed

Love of wealth turns duty into stinginess (āyah 8).



Mind the heart

What is hidden inside will be brought out (āyāt 9–10).



He is Al-Khabīr

Nothing escapes His knowledge, inner or outer (āyah 11).

إِنَّ رَبَّهُمْ بِهِمْ يَوْمَئِذٍ خَبِيرٌ

“Indeed, their Lord with them, that Day, is fully Aware.” — 100:11



References

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